

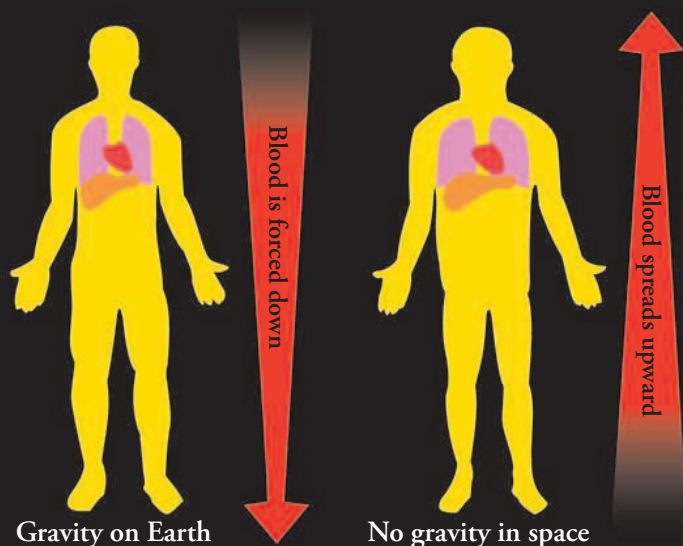
In space

When Yuri Gagarin made the first space flight in 1961, doctors had no idea what effect space travel would have on his body. Since then, nearly 700 people have flown in space, and we have discovered a lot about how the human body reacts to this extraordinary experience.



UPSIDE DOWN

On Earth, you know which way is up or down because gravity pulls your feet toward the ground. But in space there is no gravity. Your body floats around. Trainee astronauts can experience weightlessness (zero gravity) by taking flights in a specially designed aircraft known as the Vomit Comet.



This visor has a thin layer of gold to shield the eyes from the Sun's harmful rays.

FAST FACTS

- Astronauts grow up to 2 in (5 cm) taller. This is because their backbone lengthens in space. But their height returns to normal when they come back to Earth.
- Bones become weaker in space because they are not supporting the weight of the body, and without regular exercise, astronauts are prone to broken bones.

FAT FACE

On Earth, blood is drawn toward your feet by gravity. In space, your blood drifts upward, making your face fatter and your legs thinner—a condition known as bird's legs. Fluid collecting in your head also gives you a stuffy feeling, like having a cold.